VON ZAROVICH ESTATE / STATION 3

The Clockwork Observatory

The stars are watching. The clock is moving.

The stairs curl upward into a round room of brass, cold glass, and midnight blue. A painted sky sweeps across the domed ceiling. Constellations glitter overhead, their shapes half-lost among the stars. The air smells of metal polish and long-cold candle smoke.

A huge brass vault door fills the far wall. Four empty pegs sit in a row, numbered one through four, with a crank handle at the center. A small arrow and a bronze inscription catch the light above the mechanism.

On the worktable lie seven loose brass gears. Their teeth make uneven little shadows across the tabletop. Beside them sit an astrolabe and a star chart. Everything looks as though its owner stepped away in the middle of an experiment and never came back.

Then the great wall clock strikes.

Something steps out of its face: an empty suit of armor, suspended around a knot of whirring gears. A pendulum blade swings from one gauntlet. There is no person inside. There is only the ticking.

The phantom turns toward you. The vault stays shut. Tick. Tick. Tick.

What do you do? Talk with your partner. Tell the DM what you want to examine or try. Your character sheet may give you ideas.

Vault door half 1/2 - 100% print. Trim margins; tape centre edges together.

Vault door half 2/2 - 100% print. Trim margins; tape centre edges together.

Loose Brass Gears

Cut around each toothed silhouette. Keep backs blank and identical. Mix all seven before play.

Gear tokens: approximately 2 inches across. All faces use the same material, size and hub.

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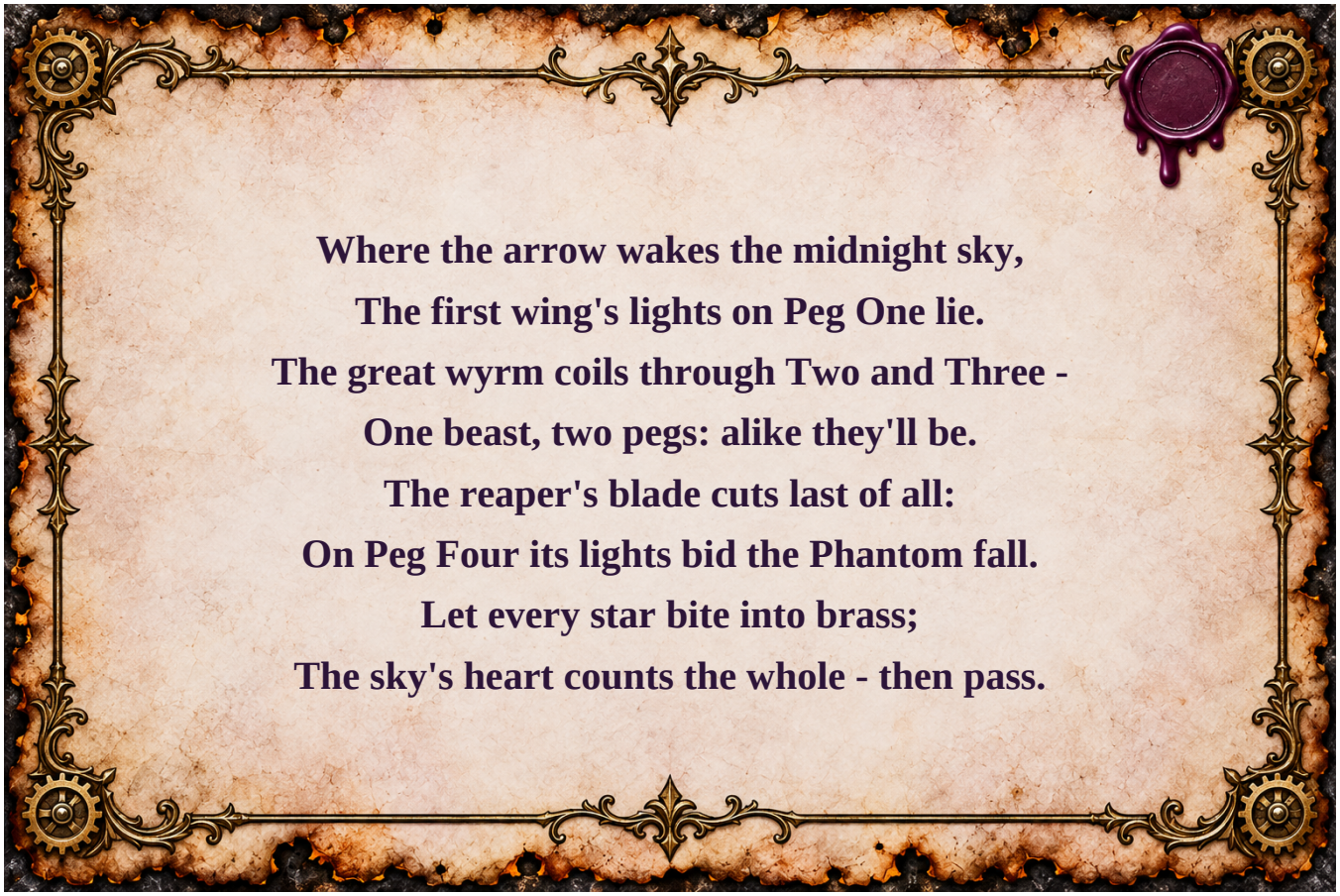
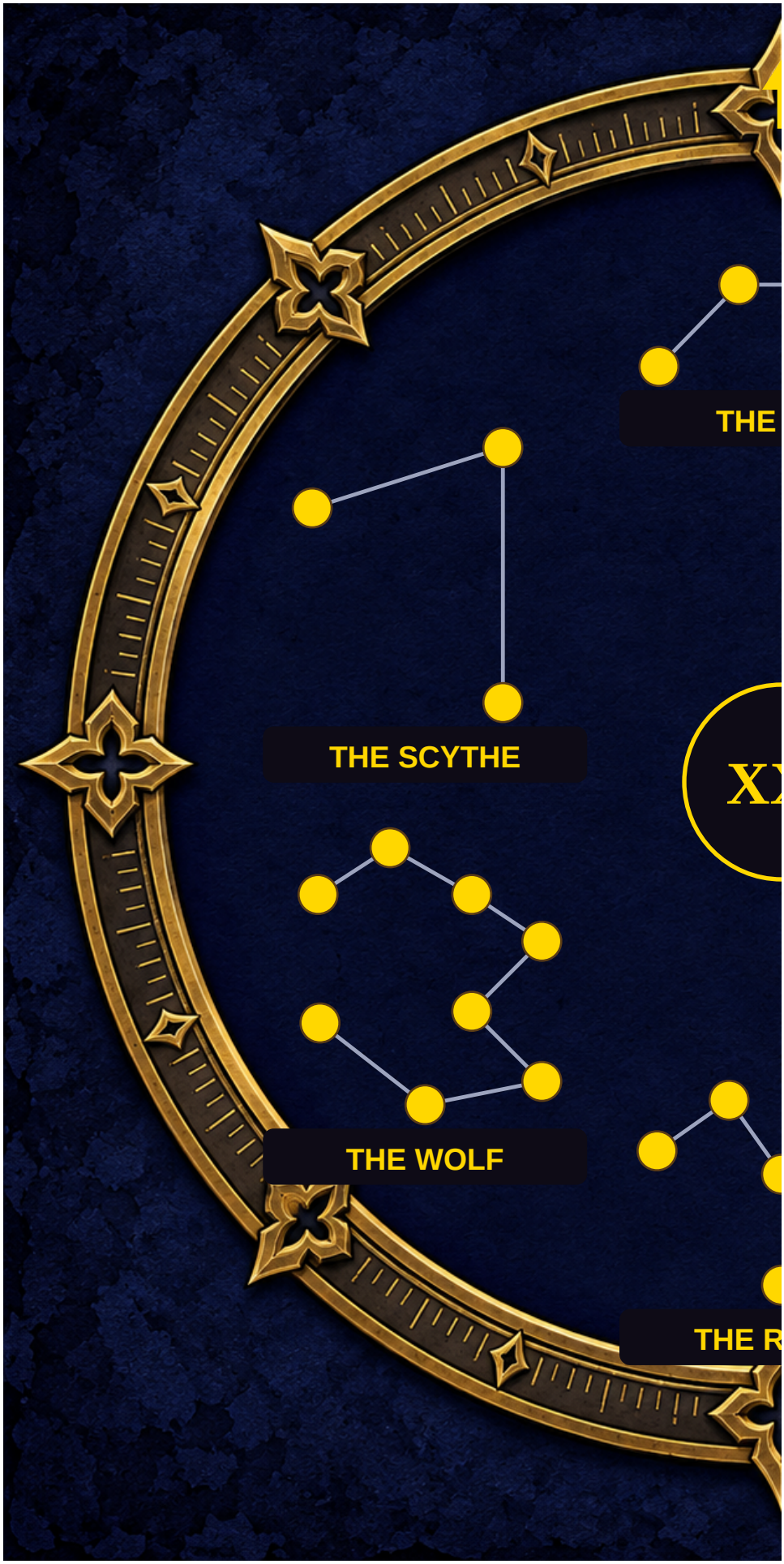
The Gilded Door Plaque

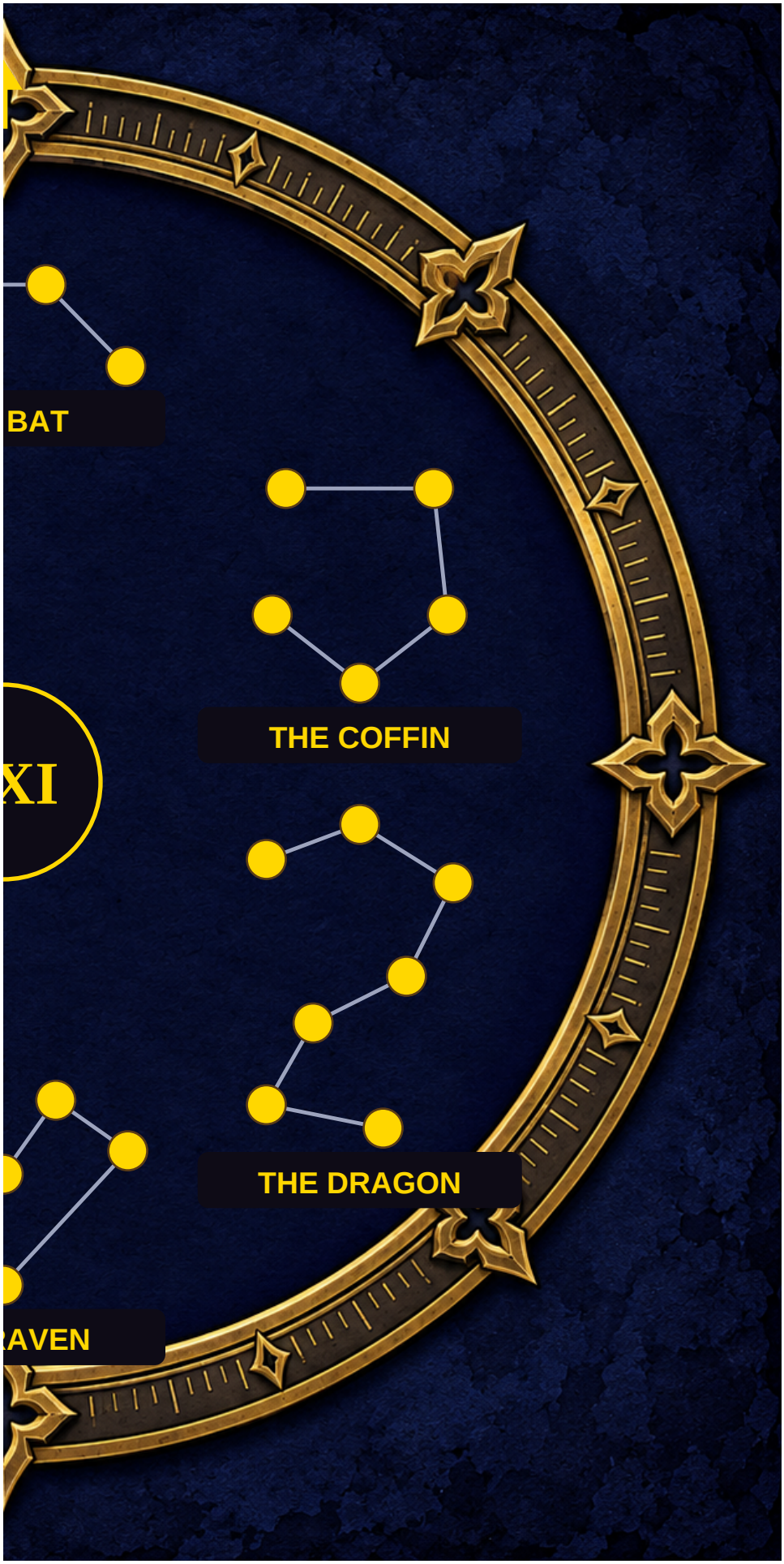
Give this plaque when the players look at the door. Cut the illustrated card out.



Starting riddle. Keep the progressive clues and answer key with the helper.



Astrolabe chart half 1/2 - 100% print. Trim margins; tape centre edges together.



Astrolabe chart half 2/2 - 100% print. Trim margins; tape centre edges together.

The Clockwork Phantom

Cut out the figure and mount in a clip or on a folded cardstock foot.

The Phantom is visible in the room at entry. The helper controls its ticking and attacks; keep its statistics and clue text hidden.

Five-inch-tall standee illustration, preserving its generated proportions.

Reward - Envelope 5

Cut out the 3-inch crest. Put it with Evidence E3 from the helper pack.

Award both crest and E3 on completion. Send the pair to the Grand Gate.

DM-held until solve. Progressive clues are in the helper pack.

STATION 3 HELPER GM — THE CLOCKWORK OBSERVATORY (GEARS & GADGETS)

Pair: Count Dracula / Drac (Bard) & Johnny (Bard) · **Goal:** load four gears on the vault door pegs in the right order and turn the crank → the Phantom is locked away → **Crest #3 + Evidence Card E3**. **Target:** 10–15 min. Full rules: `Stations/Station_3_Clockwork_Observatory_Gears_and_Gadgets.md`.

Before the players arrive

- Vault door board (PEG 1–4, crank in the centre, small ↑ above Peg 1). Seven **identical brass** gears in a jumbled pile (pencil marks on the backs are for you).
- Clockwork Phantom standee. Plaque card (hand over when anyone looks at the door). **Star chart** (hand over when anyone touches the astrolabe or desk).
- Phone timer, plus a **second alarm for the Phantom's tick** (3:00, then every 2 minutes).

Your special job: the Phantom's tick

- **Strikes at 3:00, 5:00, 7:00, 9:00, 11:00...** and **immediately after any wrong crank.** One line of narration, one roll, back to the puzzle. No initiative.
- **Scythe Sweep:** +5 to hit, **1d6+2** slashing (Drac AC 14, Johnny AC 13). Alternate targets.
- **If a target is under 10 HP:** the Phantom knocks one placed gear back into the pile instead of dealing damage.
- **Phantom:** AC 15, 22 HP, Wis save +0. At 0 HP it bursts into gears, skips its next strike, then reassembles. It can't be destroyed; only the door locks it away.
- **The crank:** a correct set opens the door. A wrong set grinds and shrieks, gives **no hint about which gear** was wrong, and the Phantom strikes at once.

Station clock

Time	Do this
0:00	Read the Player Introduction aloud. Start both timers.
2:00–3:00	**Envelope 1** if they haven't linked the star chart to the riddle.
3:00	First Phantom strike.
5:00–6:00	**Envelope 2** when Drac uses Bat Form (or Johnny makes History DC 12).
7:00	Nudge: *"The riddle says the stars* bite*. What on this table bites?"*
8:00–9:00	**Envelope 3** when they inspect the crank, or right after a first wrong crank.
11:00	Stuck, two wrong cranks in a row, or a PC under 10 HP: **Envelope 4**.
13:00	Still stuck: the frozen Phantom points at each correct gear in turn.
15:00	Lead GM's bell = hard stop. Then **Envelope 5** and send them to the Gate.

Answer key (DM eyes only)

Peg	Teeth	Constellation
1	**4**	The Bat (under the arrow)
2	**7**	The Dragon ("great wyrm")
3	**7**	The Dragon again (the twin)
4	**3**	The Scythe ("reaper's blade")
Check	4+7+7+3 = **21**	**XXI** at the chart's centre

Decoys: the Raven (6), the Coffin (5), the Wolf (8). A single decoy substitution breaks the 21 total. The total alone is not unique; check the riddle and order too.

STATION 3 HELPER GM — RUNNING THE ROOM

Character rulings (from the sheets; 3 uses each)

- **Drac, Look Into My Eyes!** (Action): the Phantom saves DC 15 Wis at +0. On a fail it **skips its next strike**. From 11:00, a success also triggers Envelope 4.
- **Drac, Bat Form** (Bonus): flies to the dome → **Envelope 2**.
- **Drac, Inspiring Bleh** (Bonus): a d8 for Johnny's next roll or save.
- **Johnny, DJ Backpack** (Reaction when the Phantom attacks him): the attack still lands, but the Phantom **skips its next strike**.
- **Johnny, Sick Beats** (once at this station): after a wrong crank, cancels that crank's strike and pops the gears back out with no penalty.
- **Johnny, Chill Vibes / Monster Mash:** a d8 for any roll, or 1d8 healing. Use freely.

Nudges (questions only)

When	Say
Only looking at gears (0–3 min)	*"What else here is the same gold as the door?"* / *"Who's checked the astrolabe?"*
Stuck on the riddle words	*"Which picture on the chart could be called that? Where's the arrow?"* / *"What does a reaper carry?"*
Drac's sheet unused (5–6 min)	*"Drac, anything on your sheet that gets you up to that ceiling?"*
Know the constellations, not what to do	*"Count something on the chart, then count something on the table."*
Full set ready	*"Before you crank it, does the riddle give you a way to check?"* / *"What's in the middle of the chart?"*

Quick rulings

- **Attacking the Phantom:** allowed and fun, but it reassembles. After a round, say: *"The pieces are already crawling back together. The* door *locks it away."*
- **Interrogating it** (Persuasion or Intimidation +7 vs DC 15): it ticks once per tooth on **one** peg. Give them Peg 1.
- **They miscount the Dragon** (6 instead of 7): don't correct them. Ask *"Does that match what the riddle says about Two and Three?"*
- **Prying the door:** it's magical and won't budge. Redirect kindly.

Don't

- Never say a tooth or star count before Envelope 4. Never say "stars equal teeth" before Envelope 3.
- Never confirm a single gear. Only a full crank gives feedback.
- Don't flip the gears over, and don't let the Phantom take more than about 30 seconds of any 2 minutes.

Reward (Envelope 5)

Hand over **Crest #3** and **Evidence Card E3**: *"Take these to the Grand Gate!"*

STATION 3 — ENVELOPE LABELS

ENVELOPE 1 · LOOK AROUND

Station 3 · Observatory. Open at **2–3 min** if they haven't linked the chart to the riddle.

ENVELOPE 2 · YOUR SHEET

Station 3 · Observatory. Open on Drac's **Bat Form** (or Johnny's History DC 12).

ENVELOPE 3 · THE RULE

Station 3 · Observatory. Open on a crank inspection or the first wrong crank (**8–9 min**).

ENVELOPE 4 · SEALED: EMERGENCY

Station 3 · Observatory. **Helper only.** At 11:00 if stuck, or after a critical mistake.

ENVELOPE 5 · REWARD

Station 3 · Observatory. Open on solve: **Crest #3 + Evidence Card E3**.

ENVELOPE CONTENTS

ENVELOPE 1 · THE PAINTED DOME (READ ALOUD)

> The clock ticks and, high above, the painted dome flickers. For a heartbeat the constellations on the ceiling glow, exactly matching the brass star chart on the desk, and a thin golden line runs from the chart's arrow down to the little arrow above Peg 1.

ENVELOPE 2 · THE GILDED STARS (READ ALOUD)

Bat Form:

> Up close, only three of the six painted constellations are inlaid with real celestial brass: the little Bat right under the arrow, the long coiled Dragon, and the curved Scythe. The Raven, the Coffin and the Wolf are just dull grey paint.

Johnny, History DC 12:

> Old Barovian stargazers called the Bat "the first wing," the Dragon "the great wyrm," and the Scythe "the reaper's blade."

ENVELOPE 3 · THE CRANK INSCRIPTION (READ ALOUD)

> Worn letters are stamped around the crank's hub: STAR FOR TOOTH · TWO AND THREE TURN AS ONE · ALL TOGETHER: THE SKY'S HEART.

Optional: after any wrong crank, Johnny may roll Performance DC 13 to hear how many *gears rang true, but not which ones.*

ENVELOPE 4 · THE HYPNOTIZED CLOCKFACE (READ ALOUD)

> The Phantom's clockface spins wildly and its ticking slows into words, the old clockmaker's rhyme: "Four in one... and three in four..." Then it freezes.

That gives Pegs 1 and 4. The twins rule plus the 21 total gives 7 + 7. At 13:00 the frozen Phantom points at each correct gear.

ENVELOPE 5 · EVIDENCE CARD E3: THE OILY FOOTPRINTS

Goes in with Crest #3.

> Gear-oil footprints lead behind the great clock: **small** boots, barely bigger than a kid's.

DM ONLY - Assembly and Validation

Answer: Pegs 1-4 = 4, 7, 7, 3. Either seven-tooth token fits either middle peg. Seven tokens total: 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 7, 8. Faces use the same material and size; keep backs unmarked or concealed.

Chart: Bat 4 (top, beneath arrow); Coffin 5 (upper right); Dragon 7 (lower right); Raven 6 (bottom); Wolf 8 (lower left); Scythe 3 (upper left). Each circular gold point counts once; lines do not add points. Centre XXI = 21. Sum alone is insufficient: 3+4+6+8 also totals 21.

Setup: tape door halves into a 15 x 10 inch board. Tape chart halves into a 10-inch square; optionally cut the circle. Jumble seven gear tokens. Place Phantom. Give plaque on door inspection and chart on astrolabe/desk inspection. Keep the crank inscription behind the screen until Envelope 3.

Coaching: ask about pictures, arrow, matching counts and character features before revealing numbers. Phantom strikes at 3:00 then every 2 minutes and after wrong cranks. No initiative; spend at most 30 seconds on a strike. See the helper pages for statistics, bailout, and character hooks.

Envelopes: cut helper page 3 into labels/contents. Clues 1-4 are read aloud by the helper at their triggers. Never give players the intact sheet. Envelope 5 needs crest and E3.

Before sealing: sample-print at 100%, check gear fit and all counts, add dice, pencil, tape, standee clip and two timers. The complete pack contains DM answers and is for assembly.